



YOU HAVE TO HAVE GOOD MEN. GOOD MEN, ALL OF THEM

DAS BOOT / 1981

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Action thriller

DIRECTOR

Wolfgang Petersen

WRITERS

Wolfgang Petersen (screenplay); Lothar-Günther Buchheim (novel)

STARS

Jürgen Prochnow, Herbert Grönemeyer, Klaus Wenneman

BEFORE

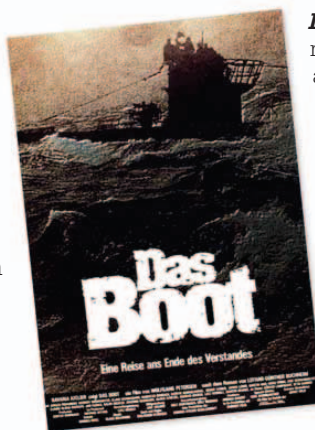
1953 Charles Frend's *The Cruel Sea*, the story of a British corvette protecting a convoy from U-boat attacks, establishes the World War II naval thriller genre.

AFTER

2009 Samuel Maoz's tense war movie, *Lebanon*, which tells its story entirely from the inside of an Israeli tank, is compared to *Das Boot* by film critics.

Wolfgang Petersen's *Das Boot* (*The Boat*) is an action movie set almost entirely in the narrowest, most claustrophobic space imaginable—a German U-boat during a single voyage in World War II. The story follows the anxieties of the crew in such a way that our attention, like theirs, is gripped within this undersea vice of iron and rivets.

After a brief scene in which the crew carouses in a French bar before a mission that seems to fill them, and the viewer, with a feeling of impending doom, the U-96 departs La Rochelle and heads deep into the North Atlantic. There the boat intercepts Allied convoys, is heavily damaged in a depth-charge attack, then makes a perilous attempt to slip undetected into the



Das Boot has been released as a movie and as a TV mini-series with added scenes. In 1997, a 209-minute director's cut was released.

Mediterranean. *Das Boot* is not a movie about heroes; its characters are all ordinary men whose survival depends on each other. "You

have to have good men," says the apolitical, battle-hardened captain. "Good men, all of them."

An antiwar war movie?

Lothar-Günther Buchheim, on whose novel the movie was based, criticized the movie for being too exciting to convey the antiwar message he intended. This echoed the view of the French director François Truffaut, who said that a true antiwar movie was impossible because such movies inevitably

“The sea cannot claim us, Henrich. No ship is as seaworthy as ours.”

Captain Lehmann-Willenbrock / *Das Boot*